

Ajay Banga: President World Bank Group

A mission to help create jobs to alleviate poverty and stimulate development and growth

His name is writ large in the annals of India's banking history. Never one shy to take on the challenges of the fast evolving global economic, financial and geopolitical scenario Ajaypal Singh Banga has proven the heft of his stature as the President of the World Bank Group since he took charge in 2023.

Buttressed by the prestigious assignments accrued during his distinguished career, foresight, focused decision-making, nimble problem-solving, and effective deliverables have become the hallmarks of Banga's management style. This is well illustrated by Banga's turnaround of the 80-year-old institution, which has gotten a good dust over to align it with today's rapidly evolving global financial ecosystem.

The processes he has put in place have demonstrated how the World Bank Group is not an altruistic entity but effective and impactful as an ally in development. The strategic framework Banga has created for the World Bank's endeavours provides plenty of elasticity for it to bend with the needs of the times, continuously evolve to remain constantly relevant.

The health of a nation hinges on a strong economy and the Banga's newly embedded reforms in the World Bank are set to bolster lending capacity, simplify operations, and deliver development solutions that are practical, scalable, and impactful.

Banga's luminous journey, after graduating from IIMA in 1981, is marked by significant signposts that illustrate the strategic thinking and learnings that have moulded his worldview. He spent 13 years at Nestle India, then at PepsiCo for 2 years, at Citigroup from 1996 to



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2009 — eventually joining Mastercard in 2010 until his retirement in 2021 as President and CEO of Mastercard. He then served as Vice Chairman at General Atlantic for two years before helming the World Bank Group as President.

All these moves are clear indicators of Banga's endeavour to continue to hone his skills to ride the rollercoaster dynamics of a rapidly changing global workplace.

A crucial aspect of the this transformation under Banga's steerage is

the World Bank's agenda to create a world free of poverty—on a liveable planet. With the rising concerns about sustainable living and inclusivity the World Bank's freshly rejigged mission addresses two very critical components of our way forward for economic development and growth worldwide.

Sharing his views on alleviating poverty, Banga points out that the best way to do so is to create jobs. Poverty, as he sees it, is both a state of mind and a state of being. For Banga, job creation is the most compelling catalyst for development— providing not just income, but also dignity and purpose.

This resonates even more strongly with India, which has been working apace to accelerate its efforts for creating employment. As ascertained by UNICEF, India has the world's largest youth population, with 371 million people in the 15 to 29 age group. A large youth population enhances workforce participation and lower dependency ratios, creating a demographic dividend for growth. It also leads to more economically active citizens, which can boost GDP growth and per capita income. According to the World Bank and NITI Aayog, tapping this potential could add up to USD 1 trillion to India's GDP by 2030.

As Banga sees it, while the government has a definitive role to play, the private sector too is pivotal to this development. It's this kind of vision with which Banga has put the spotlight on how to mobilise the power of the private sector.

Banga's relentless pursuit of excellence has been pivotal to his realigning the processes for better, speedier, more efficient future-forward result-oriented outcomes.